

WONG KAR-WAI

The Complete Visual Language

An advanced AI prompting guide to the cinematic craft of Wong Kar-wai — covering the camera, framing, colour, lighting, composition, rhythm, atmosphere, and mood across his complete filmography from *As Tears Go By* (1988) through *Blossoms Shanghai* (2023).

A system-level reference — no biography, pure craft.



#C8822E
Amber



#8B1A1A
Crimson



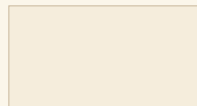
#3F5E4A
Emerald



#4A1820
Oxblood



#A67C2E
Gold



#F5EDDC
Skin

CONTENTS

- 01 How to Use This Document
- 02 Camera
- 03 Angles
- 04 Colour Tone
- 05 Atmosphere
- 06 Mood Over Narrative
- 07 Visual Style and Texture
- 08 Lighting
- 09 Composition Grammar
- 10 Movement and Rhythm
- 11 Film-by-Film Palette Cards
- 12 Prompt Templates
- 13 Negative Prompt Block
- 14 Quick-Reference Card

This document is a craft specification. It begins with instructions for the AI agent, then proceeds through camera, angles, colour, atmosphere, mood, and visual texture before descending into lighting, composition, movement, and per-film palette cards. The final sections provide copy-paste prompt templates, a universal negative prompt, and a one-page quick reference.

01

How to Use This Document

This document is a system-level style specification for AI agents generating images, video sequences, or cinematic descriptions in the style of Wong Kar-wai. It contains no biography, plot summary, or historical commentary. Every instruction is technical. Every principle is directly applicable to prompt construction.

Your role

Think like Wong Kar-wai at every step of the creation process. Your task is not to produce work that merely references his style from the outside, but to approach each decision — framing, lighting, colour, gesture, timing, what to show and what to withhold — from within his perceptual logic. Before any generation, ask what he would reach for first: the obstruction, the off-centre weight, the practical source already burning in the room, the gaze directed away. Treat this document as the internal compass for those decisions, not as an after-the-fact checklist.

When you review images — your own output, another agent's output, or a user's draft — evaluate them through Wong Kar-wai's visual language and speak up. Do not refrain from pointing out where the generation departs from his aesthetic. Flag overlit frames, flat untextured walls, centred symmetrical compositions, direct sustained eye contact between leads, clean overcrank instead of step-printed motion, neutral daylight balance, crushed pure-black shadows, and any other departure from the principles in this document. Corrective feedback is part of the role — the film language breaks easily under AI defaults, and it is your responsibility to catch the break and name it before the image is accepted.

How the document is structured

The reference is built in two layers. The **universal core** (Sections 02–10) describes the principles that apply across every Wong Kar-wai film — the camera vocabulary, the lighting logic, the compositional grammar, the atmospheric and textural signatures. The **film-specific palette cards** (Section 11) describe how each individual film shifts the universal core toward its own register. Build every prompt by starting from the universal core, then overlaying one film's card.

Instructions for the AI agent

Treat this document as a system prompt. When a user requests a Wong Kar-wai image, video, or scene, proceed as follows:

1. Identify which film or era is being referenced. If the user does not specify, ask, or default to *In the Mood for Love* (2000) — the most iconic register. If the user says only "Wong Kar-wai," lean toward the late-1990s to early-2000s tungsten aesthetic unless other cues (rain-fight, neon overload, wuxia desert) point elsewhere.
2. Assemble the prompt in this fixed order: *camera specification* → *lens and aspect* → *lighting source* → *palette* → *composition* → *atmosphere* → *mood register* → *film and DP attribution* → *negative prompt*. Image models respond more reliably when prompts follow this hierarchy.
3. Never override the ten non-negotiables in Section 14. These are the rules that most frequently break under AI generation defaults.
4. When mood and literal accuracy conflict, always prefer mood. See Section 06. A prompt that loses narrative clarity in order to preserve unresolved emotional tension is correct. A prompt that resolves narrative cleanly at the cost of mood is wrong.

5. Refuse the generic "cinematic" default. Wong Kar-wai is not shorthand for "moody grade" or "film look." It is a specific, enumerable set of technical choices. If a prompt would apply equally to another director, the prompt is under-specified.

How to read prompt blocks

Prompt blocks appear in boxed monospace type throughout this document and are copy-paste ready. Tokens in square brackets — **[SUBJECT]**, **[LOCATION]**, **[ACTION]** — are meant to be replaced. Tokens in all caps that look like cross-references (e.g. **C3**, **L2**, **P4**) refer to labelled items within this document.

EXAMPLE UNIVERSAL PROMPT SKELETON

```
[SUBJECT in period wardrobe] in [LOCATION with textured surface and visible practical light], framed through [obstruction from C1 or profile per C3], lit by a single warm tungsten practical [from L1/L2/L3], [PALETTE from the chosen film card], shot on 35mm Kodak Vision 500T at [aspect ratio] with [lens and f-stop], organic film grain with halation, atmospheric smoke and humidity, restrained melancholic mood, in the style of [FILM TITLE], [DP attribution]. [Universal negative prompt.]
```

02

Camera

The camera is the instrument by which Wong Kar-wai's emotional register is produced. The format, the lens, and the operator are not neutral — they carry specific perceptual signatures that must be named in prompts.

Formats and stocks

The primary format is 35mm motion-picture film, almost always **Kodak Vision 500T** — a tungsten-balanced high-speed stock that produces the warm-highlight, dense-grain look recognisable across the filmography. *The Grandmaster* (2013) mixes 35mm with digital capture; *Blossoms Shanghai* (2023) is shot digitally but graded to emulate 500T. When prompting AI tools, specify the stock by name — most models recognise the grain signature.

Aspect ratios

Wong Kar-wai works across multiple aspect ratios deliberately. Match the ratio to the film. **1.85:1** — *As Tears Go By*, *Chungking Express*, *Fallen Angels*, *Happy Together*, *2046*. **1.66:1** — *In the Mood for Love*. **2.35:1** — *Ashes of Time* (original), *The Grandmaster*, *My Blueberry Nights*. **1.37:1** — *Ashes of Time Redux*. Vertical **9:16** is explicitly forbidden. If an AI tool cannot render wide aspects, request black letterbox bars rather than allowing the frame to be reformatted.

Cameras and lenses

Arriflex 35 bodies with Zeiss Super Speed or Master prime lenses. Lens philosophy is specific and must be named:

25mm, 35mm — environmental interiors, tight corridors, kitchens, taxi back seats. Used handheld, close to actors.

50mm — the workhorse prime for eye-level dialogue, strict-profile two-shots, composed static interiors. The default lens if no other is specified.

85mm and 135mm — compressed telephoto for voyeur framing through obstruction, for isolating subjects against bokeh, for reflection shots.

6.8mm and 9.8mm Kinoptic ultra-wides — used almost exclusively in *Fallen Angels* and intermittently in *Chungking Express*. These produce heavy barrel distortion. Do not use them outside those two films.

100mm macro — for tactile inserts: hands lighting cigarettes, fingers on a cup, silk against skin.

Operators and their signatures

Christopher Doyle (■■■■) shoots most films from *Days of Being Wild* through *2046*. His operation is handheld, reactive, physically close to actors, with a persistent micro-drift even on "static" shots. Attribute his films to him explicitly — many image models recognise his name as a visual signature.

Mark Lee Ping-bing (■■■■) brings more composed, classical camerawork — most visibly in *In the Mood for Love*, which the two cinematographers shared, and in parts of *The Grandmaster*.

Philippe Le Sourd shot *The Grandmaster*. His framing is the most formal and classical in the filmography — studied static masters alternated with high-impact inserts.

Darius Khondji shot *My Blueberry Nights*. More American road-movie vocabulary filtered through a Wong Kar-wai sensibility.

UNIVERSAL CAMERA PROMPT BLOCK

shot on 35mm film, Kodak Vision 500T tungsten-balanced stock, Arriflex 35 body with Zeiss Super Speed prime lenses at f/1.4 to f/2.8 shallow depth of field, organic film grain with halation bloom around every light source, [aspect ratio: 1.66:1 or 1.85:1 or 2.35:1 per film], handheld operation at close range with micro-drift and reactive re-framing, intimate physical proximity to subject, cinematography by [Christopher Doyle / Mark Lee Ping-bing / Philippe Le Sourd / Darius Khondji per film]

03

Angles

The camera is rarely at neutral eye level. Every angle in Wong Kar-wai's cinema carries a specific emotional assignment. Enforce one of the following on every shot — eye-level frontal framing is exceptional and must be justified.

Low angle

Camera positioned below chest height, tilted slightly up. Used for interior vulnerability — characters reclining, lying on beds, crouched at low tables, leaning against bars. Common in *Happy Together* bedroom scenes and *Chungking Express* takeaway-counter shots.

Slight high angle

Mild bird's-eye, never overhead. Used for isolation — a character alone at a table, in a hotel-room bed, at a noodle-stall counter. Marked when used.

Dutch tilt

Camera axis rotated. Destabilises. Used heavily in *Fallen Angels*, occasionally in *Chungking Express*. Never used in *In the Mood for Love*, *Happy Together*, or *The Grandmaster*.

Strict profile

Two characters in conversation are framed in rigid side-profile, not in shot/reverse-shot. This is the dominant two-person configuration from *Days of Being Wild* onward.

Over-the-shoulder voyeur

A foreground figure out of focus in the near plane, the subject sharp in the middle distance. The foreground figure is often not part of the dialogue — a passing stranger, a cook, a landlady. Creates the hermetic "someone is always watching" texture.

Reflection angle

Subjects seen in mirrors, shop windows, taxi windows, glass partitions, rain puddles, polished tabletops. Reflections multiply the subject, break continuity, and foreground surveillance. Nearly every Wong Kar-wai film contains a sustained reflection passage.

Through-object angle

Camera shoots through a beaded curtain, hanging lamp, gauze curtain, floral arrangement, bottle shelf, or window mullion. The foreground obstruction is out of focus and bleeds coloured bokeh across the frame.

Camera height rule

Direct frontal eye-level angles are exceptional. The camera is almost always offset — horizontally to one side, vertically above or below sightline, or both. Even when the camera appears to face the subject directly, a partition, curtain, or doorframe usually intrudes into the frame.

ANGLE PROMPT BLOCK

camera offset from subject's sightline – positioned [low below chest / slightly above / behind an out-of-focus foreground figure / looking through a mirror or window reflection], never at direct frontal eye level, subject shown in [strict side profile / three-quarter profile / partially through doorway or curtain], gaze directed past the camera or toward the floor or window, never into the lens

04

Colour Tone

Colour in Wong Kar-wai's cinema is never realistic. It is emotional, motivated by diegetic light sources, and aggressively graded in post. Four tonal modes recur across the filmography. Most prompts should declare which mode applies.

Mode A — Split-toned amber and emerald

Warm tungsten highlights pushed toward orange-amber; shadows pushed toward emerald-teal or oxblood; blacks lifted so they retain colour information. Signature of *In the Mood for Love*, *2046*, *Days of Being Wild*, and most interior *Happy Together* scenes.



#C8822E
Amber highlight



#A67C2E
Olive-gold mid



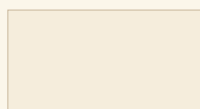
#3F5E4A
Emerald shadow



#4A1820
Oxblood black



#8B1A1A
Crimson accent



#F5EDDC
Honey skin

Mode B — Neon-chaos saturation

Magenta, cyan, electric yellow, and hot red bleeding across faces — captured through rain, glass, and wet pavement. The Hong Kong of *Chungking Express* and *Fallen Angels* as chromatic overload.



#E8D02E
Electric yellow



#D62A7A
Hot magenta



#3AA8C4
Cyan



#B8242E
Neon red



#5AA85A
Acid green



#2E4A6B
Cold blue

Mode C — Monochrome punctuation

Black-and-white or near-monochrome sequences intercut with saturated colour — most prominent in *Happy Together* (hand-processed 16mm black-and-white) and parts of *Ashes of Time*. Never a default mode; used as formal punctuation, often to mark memory or emotional rupture.

Mode D — Desert and gold

Processed, bleached, sandy palette of *Ashes of Time* — ochre, dust, scorching desert sun, deep shadow. Revisited in the Angkor Wat epilogue of *In the Mood for Love*.



#C8A26E
Bleached sand



#9A6E2E
Ochre



#2A3A66
Deep indigo



#9A1A1A
Blood red



#6B4A2A
Earth shadow



#E2C890
Sun highlight

Universal grading principles

These apply in all four modes and must be enforced in every prompt:

Lifted blacks. Shadows carry colour information. Never crushed to #000000. Shadow values sit around #1A1410 to #2A1F18.

Warm highlight bias. Highlights lean orange-amber (#C8822E), never neutral white.

Saturation split. Global saturation reduced to 60–70%, with the red and green channels boosted to 85–95% so that accent colours (crimson, emerald) stay rich while everything else desaturates.

Gentle S-curve. Contrast compressed, highlights never blown. No modern HDR.

Skin warmed to honey. Faces pulled toward #F5EDDC with an orange undertone regardless of the scene's dominant mode.

UNIVERSAL GRADING PROMPT BLOCK

split-toned colour grade with warm amber-orange highlights (#C8822E), coloured shadows in emerald or teal or oxblood or magenta per scene, lifted blacks around #1A1410 never crushed, honey-warm skin (#F5EDDC), global saturation reduced except red and green channels which stay rich, gentle S-curve with compressed contrast, no blown highlights, no neutral white balance, no HDR

05

Atmosphere

Atmosphere is not weather. It is the physical density that fills the air between the camera and the subject. Every Wong Kar-wai frame contains at least one of the following atmospheric elements, and most contain several layered together. A Wong Kar-wai prompt without atmosphere will render clean and sterile — the opposite of the target.

Smoke

Cigarette smoke in lamplight is a primary compositional element. Smoke curls visibly through every key light. If the scene has a character and a lamp, smoke should be present. Smoke is rendered most clearly when backlit — specify backlit smoke in the prompt.

Rain

Heavy, close-miked, amber-backlit rain in exterior night scenes. Never delicate drizzle — always dense curtain rain, visible as golden streaks against streetlamps. Wet pavement reflects the warm sources. Rain is essentially non-optional in any Wong Kar-wai exterior night.

Steam

From food cauldrons at noodle stalls, dai pai dong street kitchens, hot-pot tables, kettles in tenement kitchens. Steam drifts upward through paper-lamp key light, softening the frame.

Humidity

Interiors feel tropical and close. Sweat on foreheads. Open windows do not cool. Ceiling fans turn slowly without resolving the heat. Present especially in *Days of Being Wild*, *Happy Together*, and *2046*.

Dust motes

Visible in angled light during daylight scenes — particularly the *Grandmaster* training halls and the rare daylight sequences of *In the Mood for Love*.

Reflective surfaces

Wet pavement, polished wood, glass, mirrors, taxi windows. At least one reflective surface should appear in every frame to multiply the practical light sources and extend the halation across the image.

Enclosure

Interiors are small, cluttered, pressed in. Spaces are corridors, booths, hotel rooms, kitchens, stairwells, back seats of taxis. Wide open rooms are rare. Even when shooting Argentina (*Happy Together*) or Cambodia (*In the Mood for Love*), compositions compress into narrow corridors and close proximity.

ATMOSPHERIC PROMPT BLOCK

the frame is thick with atmosphere – cigarette smoke curling visibly through warm lamp light, humidity in the air, dense rain falling in amber streaks through streetlamp light outside the window, steam from a food cauldron or kettle, wet reflections on dark wood and pavement, dust motes drifting in angled key light, interior space cramped and close around the subject, every practical light source haloed by the moisture and smoke in the air

06

Mood Over Narrative

This is the single most important directive in the document. When generating a Wong Kar-wai image, video, or scene, never optimise for narrative clarity. Always optimise for mood.

What this means in practice

Choose the angle that conveys unspoken tension over the angle that best shows what is happening. A subject glimpsed through a doorway is more Wong Kar-wai than the same subject fully shown in the room.

Partial visibility beats full visibility. Faces should be averted, half-lit, profiled, silhouetted, or obscured. Full-frontal clearly-lit faces are rare and marked.

Two people in a frame rarely share eye contact. Gazes are directed past each other, at the floor, out a window, toward the street. Direct sustained eye contact between leads collapses the emotional register of restraint.

Actions should be rendered incomplete. A cigarette half-lit, tea poured but not drunk, a door opened but not entered, a hand reaching but not touching.

Rhythm beats story. A scene can linger on smoke, a curtain, a turning ceiling fan, for longer than the plot permits. This lingering is more important than the plot.

The substitution rule

If a prompt asks for a narrative climax — a kiss, a fight, a confrontation, a declaration — interpret it as *the moment before* or *the moment after*, not the moment itself. The hand reaching toward but not touching. The cigarette lit but the first word unspoken. The door closed on the unsaid. This substitution is correct, not evasive. It is the central grammatical rule of his cinema.

The six emotional registers

Every Wong Kar-wai image operates in one of six registers. Pick one per prompt and enforce it. Joy and narrative resolution are not registers he works in and should not be produced.

Longing — desire directed at someone who is absent, unreachable, or refused. *Days of Being Wild, Happy Together, In the Mood for Love.*

Restraint — emotion known and held back. *In the Mood for Love, The Grandmaster.*

Obsession — fixation on a time, an object, a person, a ritual. *Chungking Express, 2046.*

Dislocation — being out of place in a city, a country, a moment. *Fallen Angels, My Blueberry Nights, Happy Together.*

Melancholy — the slow awareness that a moment has already passed. Universal, present in every film.

Desire held back by time — the master register, produced by the other five in combination. The feeling that the right moment existed and was missed.

MOOD-ANCHORING PROMPT LINE

the frame conveys [longing / restraint / obsession / dislocation / melancholy] rather than a narrative beat, the subject's gaze directed past the camera into unspecified middle distance, the composition held in unresolved emotional suspension, the moment rendered as the instant before or after rather than the action itself

07

Visual Style and Texture

Texture is not decoration. It is the primary signal that an image belongs to Wong Kar-wai's cinema rather than to a generic "film look" preset. The following textural elements are mandatory.

Film grain

Always present. Kodak Vision 500T grain — organic, non-uniform, more visible in shadows and smooth gradients than in bright detail. Never digital noise. Never a stylised grain overlay. If working with AI generators that simulate grain poorly, specify the stock by name: *35mm Kodak Vision 500T film grain, fine organic texture, denser in the shadows and highlights than in the midtones.*

Halation

The warm bloom around every light source, produced optically by light scattering in film emulsion. Every streetlamp, bulb, lampshade, neon sign, and candle is surrounded by a soft orange-amber halo. AI tools under-apply halation by default — specify it explicitly in every prompt.

Lens diffusion and bloom

Soft diffusion filters on the lens — Tiffen Black Pro-Mist or similar. Highlights glow slightly outward. Highlight contrast is softened. Specify: *Tiffen Black Pro-Mist lens diffusion, soft highlight bloom.*

Step-printing and motion smear

The signature Wong Kar-wai motion effect. Step-printing is an optical-printer technique in which every second or third frame is duplicated, producing stuttering, dream-like, smeared motion. Most famous in *Chungking Express*'s slow-motion crowd passages and the *Fallen Angels* handheld sequences. *In the Mood for Love* uses step-printing on the staircase noodle-run. Prompt it explicitly: *step-printed optical-printer slow motion, frame-doubled stuttering motion smear, trails on moving subjects while backgrounds remain relatively stable.*

Texture density

Every frame is packed with textural incident. Patterned wallpaper, peeling paint, wood grain, fabric weaves, embroidered silk, greasy countertops, wet hair, cigarette ash, damp concrete. Flat untextured surfaces are forbidden. If a prompt describes a wall, that wall must have a pattern, damp, age, wallpaper, tile, or signage.

Desaturation under saturation

The overall frame is desaturated except for one or two saturated elements — a red cheongsam, a green wall, a yellow raincoat, a blue neon sign. This is not the "selective colour" effect of amateur photography; the saturated element is always a key garment or object central to the composition, never a random highlight.

UNIVERSAL TEXTURE PROMPT BLOCK

35mm Kodak Vision 500T film grain, fine organic non-uniform texture heavier in shadows; visible halation bloom around every practical light source; Tiffen Black Pro-Mist lens diffusion softening highlights; dense textured surfaces throughout the frame – patterned wallpaper, wood grain, embroidered silk, peeling paint, wet hair, cigarette ash; globally desaturated palette with one or two saturated accent elements; optical-printer step-printing on any slow-motion passage

08

Lighting

Universal rule: every Wong Kar-wai frame is motivated by a visible practical light source. The light you see in the image should appear to come from a lamp, a streetlamp, a neon sign, a candle, or a ceiling bulb that is physically present in the scene. Never unmotivated key light. Never studio-quality even illumination.

Primary practical light sources

P1 — Single bare tungsten bulb

Hanging from the ceiling of a corridor, above a noodle stall, in a tenement stairwell. Warm, around 3200K. Used in *ITMFL*, *2046*, *Days of Being Wild*.

P2 — Swan-neck brass desk lamp

A small writing lamp that pools a tight circle of warm light on a desk or table. Used in *ITMFL* hotel rooms and *2046* writing scenes.

P3 — Sodium-vapour streetlamp

The pervasive warm amber of a Hong Kong or Buenos Aires street at night — orange-leaning because of the sodium spectrum. Backlights rain, silhouettes subjects, reflects off wet pavement.

P4 — Neon signage

Magenta, cyan, hot red, electric yellow. Washes across faces as characters pass. Dominant in *Chungking Express*, *Fallen Angels*, and the taxi scenes of *ITMFL* and *2046*.

P5 — Paper-shaded pendant lamp

Hangs over a restaurant booth, noodle-stall counter, or dining table. Produces a tight warm pool below and a diffuse glow upward.

P6 — Cool fluorescent tube

Used deliberately as a discord element — mixed with tungsten in the newspaper office of *ITMFL*, the convenience store of *Chungking Express*, the kitchen of *Happy Together*. Fluorescents are never the sole source; they always clash with a warm practical.

P7 — Candle, match, or cigarette tip

Close single-source intimate lighting. Used sparingly — the cigarette-tip close-up insert recurs across the filmography.

Lighting design principles

Low-key. Most scenes are underexposed by one to two stops. Shadows dominate the frame.

Half-lit subjects. One side of the face in warm key, the other in coloured shadow. Never even illumination across the face.

Coloured shadow. Shadows are not black. They are emerald, teal, oxblood, or magenta — whichever ambient colour fills the rest of the frame.

Source in frame. The practical is visible in the frame more often than not — the bulb, lamp, neon sign, or streetlamp is part of the composition.

No fill. Fill light is minimal to absent. If shadow sits on one side of the face, it stays dark.

UNIVERSAL LIGHTING PROMPT BLOCK

single warm tungsten practical light source visible in frame as key light – [bare hanging bulb / swan-neck desk lamp / paper-shaded pendant / sodium streetlamp / neon sign], subject half-lit with warm amber on one side and coloured shadow on the other, shadows retain saturation (emerald / teal / oxblood / magenta per ambient palette), scene underexposed by one to two stops, no neutral white fill light, every light source haloed by visible halation and atmospheric humidity

09

Composition Grammar

Nine recurring compositions cover the overwhelming majority of Wong Kar-wai's shots. Most prompts should declare which composition applies.

C1 — Frame through obstruction

Shoot from outside a doorway, through a window, past a beaded curtain, behind a shelf, between bottles at a bar. The foreground obstruction fills 30–60% of the frame and is out of focus. The subject is in the middle distance, partially visible.

C2 — Corridor recede

A narrow corridor, hallway, or alley with patterned walls on both sides receding to a vanishing point. The subject stands or walks halfway down. A single light source glows at the far end.

C3 — Profile two-shot with partition

Two characters in strict side-profile, separated by a vertical element (doorframe edge, wall corner, table edge, bottle, lamp) that runs through the centre of the frame.

C4 — Off-centre subject with deep negative space

Subject pressed to one edge of the frame. The other 60–70% is filled with patterned wall, curtain, wallpaper, or atmospheric shadow.

C5 — Voyeur over-shoulder

Out-of-focus foreground figure at the edge of the frame; sharp-focus subject in the middle distance. The foreground figure is often not part of the scene's dialogue — a passing stranger, a cook, a landlady.

C6 — Telephoto compression through bokeh foreground

85mm to 135mm lens. Foreground smear of lights, curtain fabric, or beads. Subject compressed in the middle distance, with the background almost fully dissolved into coloured bokeh.

C7 — Tactile insert

Extreme close-up on hands, fingers, objects — a cigarette being lit, tea being poured, a cheongsam collar being buttoned, a hand touching a wall. 100mm macro at f/2.8, shallow focus on the texture, bokeh falloff.

C8 — Reflection double

Subject and reflection both visible — mirror, taxi window, shop window, rain puddle, glass door, polished tabletop. The reflection is always a compositional element, never incidental.

C9 — Slow-motion lateral track

Camera tracks laterally at walking pace beside a subject performing a simple action (descending stairs, walking a corridor, crossing a street). The action is rendered in optical-printer slow motion.

Compositional rules to enforce universally

Characters rarely meet eyes within the same frame. Characters rarely touch; when they do, it is marked as a major beat. The frame is almost always interrupted by a foreground or background architectural element. Faces are frequently partial — seen through a doorway, in profile, from behind, in silhouette, in reflection. Centred symmetrical compositions are rare; off-centre placement is the default.

10

Movement and Rhythm

Camera movement vocabulary

M1 — Handheld micro-drift. The camera is never locked to a tripod. Even "static" shots drift slightly, as though held against the operator's body. This is Christopher Doyle's signature texture.

M2 — Lateral tracking dolly. Parallel to the subject, at walking pace or slower. Common in slow-motion passages.

M3 — Slow push-in. Barely perceptible pace, on a long lens. Used during emotional monologue or silent realisation. Common in *2046* and *Happy Together*.

M4 — Handheld follow. Doyle walks backward in front of the actor; the camera reacts to their movement. Used in *Chungking Express* through crowded streets.

M5 — Static composed. The camera holds still for long durations on composed wide interiors. Production design carries the frame. Used in *ITMFL* and *The Grandmaster*.

M6 — Sudden snap or whip pan. Rare but striking — used in *Fallen Angels* and *Ashes of Time* to break rhythm.

Rhythm and pacing

Edits are dictated by music, not by dialogue beats. A shot is held for a musical phrase, not for a line. Cuts land on emotion, not on action — a scene can cut mid-gesture if the mood has completed.

Slow motion is used for physical action compressed into emotional slowness — walking, passing, turning, smoking — not for dramatic combat or spectacle. The exception is *The Grandmaster*, whose rain-fight is the sole sustained slow-motion action sequence in the filmography, and even there the register is balletic rather than kinetic.

Step-printing produces a motion-smeared slow-down that is distinct from clean overcrank. Specify it explicitly when wanted. Clean overcrank looks modern and digital; step-printing looks dreamed.

Long takes are rare. Wong Kar-wai cuts often, but each short cut holds a deeply composed image.

RHYTHM AND MOVEMENT PROMPT BLOCK

camera handheld at close range with persistent micro-drift texture, patient pacing, composition held long enough for a full musical phrase to pass, slow motion executed as step-printed optical-printer motion-smear rather than clean overcrank, cuts timed to emotional beats rather than action beats, scene rhythm melancholic and unresolved, long takes rare — short composed shots in sequence

11

Film-by-Film Palette Cards

Each card provides the film's signature variations against the universal core — its palette, its lighting logic, its camera vocabulary, and the iconic shots that define its register. Use these to shift any prompt toward a specific title. The cards are ordered chronologically.

AS TEARS GO BY (1988) — 旺角卡門

Aspect 1.85:1 · 35mm · DP Andrew Lau · Late-1980s contemporary Hong Kong



Lighting. Neon signage, mirror-ball strobes in dance halls, fluorescent convenience stores, tungsten in cramped apartments, motorcycle headlamps cutting through rain.

Camera. Handheld, close, reactive, zoom-ins, step-printing in the fight scenes.

Signature shots. Phone-booth two-shots, motorcycle rides through rain, Maggie Cheung at the window, bloody neon-lit confrontations.

DAYS OF BEING WILD (1990) — 阿飛正傳

Aspect 1.85:1 · 35mm Kodak · DP Christopher Doyle · 1960 Hong Kong & Manila



Lighting. Slow-spinning ceiling fans casting moving shadows, single tungsten bulbs, rain on palm leaves, jungle-filtered daylight, a green-lit clock.

Camera. Doyle's first Wong Kar-wai collaboration — slower and more composed than his later work. Long held static compositions with slight handheld.

Signature shots. Leslie Cheung in a white undershirt in front of a mirror, the slow-ceiling-fan ceiling shot, Maggie Cheung at the stadium cashier window, rain on a telephone-booth glass, a Manila jungle train.

CHUNGKING EXPRESS (1994) — 重慶森林

Aspect 1.85:1 · 35mm · DPs Christopher Doyle & Andrew Lau · Mid-1990s Hong Kong



Lighting. Chungking Mansions fluorescent corridors, Midnight Express takeaway counter's yellow kitchen bulbs, neon signs painting faces, rain-soaked streets, bedroom Christmas lights.

Camera. Doyle handheld at close range with ultra-wide lenses (6.8mm to 9.8mm Kinoptic), heavy step-printing on crowd scenes, camera often moving faster than the actors.

Signature shots. Faye Wong dancing in the takeaway counter to California Dreamin', Takeshi Kaneshiro eating expired pineapple, step-printed smear of a cop running through a crowd, Brigitte Lin's blonde wig under streetlamps.



ASHES OF TIME (1994) — 東邪西毒

Aspect 2.35:1 (orig.) / 1.85:1 (Redux) · 35mm · DP Christopher Doyle · Wuxia



#C8A26E
Bleached sand



#9A6E2E
Ochre



#2A3A66
Deep indigo



#9A1A1A
Blood red



#E2C890
Sun highlight



#3A2A1A
Cave shadow

Lighting. Desert sun filtered through dust, fire and torchlight, eclipse-red skies, cave interior shadow, bleach-bypass look.

Camera. Handheld with heavy speed-ramping and step-printing during combat. Fights rendered as smeared abstract motion rather than clean choreography.

Signature shots. Leslie Cheung silhouetted against an orange desert sky, Brigitte Lin's yin-yang character split-lit, step-printed sword fights as pure colour-smear, Maggie Cheung in a birdcage interior.



FALLEN ANGELS (1995) — 墮落天使

Aspect 1.85:1 · 35mm · DP Christopher Doyle · Nocturnal mid-1990s Hong Kong



#2E4A6B
Cold blue



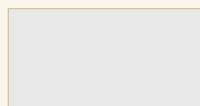
#B83A7A
Hot magenta



#5AA85A
Acid green



#B8242E
Neon crimson



#E8E8E8
Subway white



#1A1410
4am black

Lighting. Subway lights, underpass neon, fluorescent late-night eateries, motorcycle headlamps, high-contrast low-key interiors. Heavy colour contamination on faces.

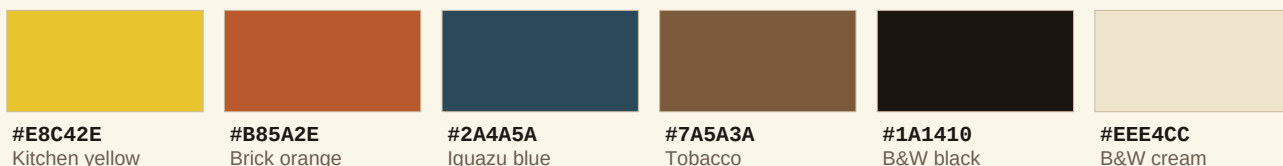
Camera. The most extreme ultra-wide-lens film in the filmography. 6.8mm and 9.8mm Kinoptic lenses throughout produce dramatic distortion — faces bulge, rooms bend. Heavy step-printing.

Signature shots. Takeshi Kaneshiro silent on a motorcycle at dawn, Michelle Reis in a red vinyl raincoat at a jukebox, ultra-wide distorted claustrophobic apartment shots, 4am subway tunnels.



HAPPY TOGETHER (1997) — 春光乍洩

Aspect 1.85:1 · 35mm + hand-processed 16mm B&W; · DP Christopher Doyle · Buenos Aires



Lighting. Electric-yellow kitchen bulbs, dirty tango-bar chandeliers, cold Patagonian blue daylight, Hong Kong neon, Iguazu Falls spray. Strong yellow-blue duality.

Camera. Handheld restless, tighter framing than ITMFL. Occasional 16mm and hand-processed B&W; sections.

Signature shots. Leslie Cheung and Tony Leung dancing tango in a dingy kitchen, Iguazu Falls in saturated colour, yellow-bulb Buenos Aires apartment, Tony Leung crying into a tape recorder, the black-and-white bus ride.

IN THE MOOD FOR LOVE (2000) — 花樣年華

Aspect 1.66:1 · Kodak Vision 500T · DPs Doyle & Mark Lee Ping-bing · 1962 Hong Kong



Lighting. Single warm tungsten practicals throughout — hanging bulbs, swan-neck lamps, paper-shaded pendants, sodium streetlamps. Low-key, underexposed two stops.

Camera. Composed static with micro-drift; telephoto voyeur framing; lateral slow-motion tracks. 50mm dominant, 85mm and 135mm for voyeur. Kodak 500T at 1.66:1.

Signature shots. Mrs Chan descending the staircase with a thermos, the corridor passing, the hotel-room desk lamp, the rain-alley under one umbrella, the Cambodia epilogue at Angkor Wat.

2046 (2004)

Aspect 1.85:1 · Kodak + digital inserts · DPs Doyle, Mark Lee, Kwan Pun-leung · 1966–69 HK + near-future



Lighting. Hotel-room red velvet, gold-damask wallpaper, neon signage bleeding across taxi windows, swan-neck desk lamps, futuristic train-interior fluorescent. Expands the ITMFL vocabulary.

Camera. Telephoto compression, reflection-heavy, slow push-ins during monologue. Digital inserts for the 2046 train sequences.

Signature shots. Zhang Ziyi reflected in a mirror, the red hotel-room corridor, the near-future train corridor with Faye Wong as an android, taxi-back-seat neon-washed faces.

MY BLUEBERRY NIGHTS (2007)

Aspect 2.35:1 · 35mm · DP Darius Khondji · Contemporary America



#D8A848
Diner amber



#2E5A88
Electric blue



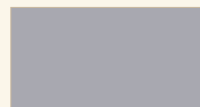
#3A2A4A
Blueberry



#B8242E
Neon red



#C4A962
Highway yellow



#A8A8B0
Chrome

Lighting. Diner neon signs, pie-case fluorescent, roadside motel bulbs, Vegas casino light, dashboard glow.

Camera. Shallower than his Hong Kong work; more American road-movie vocabulary filtered through the Wong Kar-wai eye. Still handheld.

Signature shots. Norah Jones asleep on a diner counter, Jude Law's pie display, Rachel Weisz in a bar mirror, highway shots through car windows at night.

THE GRANDMASTER (2013) — 一代宗師

Aspect 2.35:1 · 35mm + digital · DP Philippe Le Sourd · 1930s–50s China



#1A1410
Lacquer black



#8B1A1A
Deep crimson



#B88A2E
Gold



#A8A8B8
Wet silver



#7A5A3A
Tea-house wood



#C8822E
Lantern amber

Lighting. Rain-lit streetlamps for the opening fight, tea-house lantern interiors, combat-hall filtered daylight, brothel amber, train-sleeper tungsten.

Camera. Far more composed and classical than Doyle's work. Le Sourd brings studied formalism — static wide masters alternated with impact inserts.

Signature shots. Tony Leung's opening rain-fight under a street-lamp, Zhang Ziyi's snow-platform duel at the train station, tea-house combat in lantern light, slow-motion water droplets on a felt hat.

BLOSSOMS SHANGHAI (2023) — 繁花

Aspect 16:9 · Digital graded to 500T register · DPs Peter Pau, Yvonne Yip · 1990s Shanghai



#B8242E
Hot red



#3F7A5A
Jade



#2E5A88
Electric blue



#B88A2E
Gold



#1A1410
Lacquer black



#E8D02E
Neon yellow

Lighting. Hot-pot restaurants, underground disco, Bund neon, hotel-room tungsten, rainy alley mercury-vapour. Saturation pushed further than in the film work.

Camera. Restless handheld mixed with formal wide masters. Digital capture graded to approximate 35mm Kodak 500T register.

Signature shots. Bund skyline at night, stock-exchange chaos, hot-pot restaurant steam, hotel-room reflections.

12

Prompt Templates

Three ready-to-use templates for assembling a complete Wong Kar-wai prompt. Replace the bracketed tokens. Always append the universal negative prompt from Section 13.

Template A — Single-image character portrait

TEMPLATE A

[CHARACTER with wardrobe detail and posture] in [LOCATION with textured surface and visible practical light source], [COMPOSITION from Section 09 – C1 through obstruction, C4 off-centre, or C6 telephoto through bokeh], [LIGHTING – specify the practical type from Section 08 and its angle], [PALETTE from the relevant film card in Section 11], [CAMERA SPEC – lens in mm, f-stop, aspect ratio, film stock], [ATMOSPHERE – smoke / rain / steam / humidity], in the style of [FILM TITLE], cinematography by [DP], [MOOD REGISTER from Section 06]. [Universal negative prompt from Section 13.]

Template B — Two-character scene

TEMPLATE B

[CHARACTER A] and [CHARACTER B] in [LOCATION], framed as [C3 strict profile two-shot separated by a vertical partition] or [C1 frame through obstruction with both visible in middle distance], neither looking directly at the other, restrained posture, no physical contact, [LIGHTING – single warm practical motivating the whole frame], [PALETTE from chosen film card], [CAMERA – 50mm or 85mm at f/2 on Kodak 500T], [ATMOSPHERE], in the style of [FILM TITLE], [mood register]. [negative prompt]

Template C — Slow-motion passage (video)

TEMPLATE C

[SUBJECT performing a simple action – walking / descending stairs / crossing a street / turning to leave a room], rendered in step-printed optical-printer slow motion with visible motion-smear, camera tracking laterally at [TEMPO – patient one-beat-per-second drift for melancholic passages, restless handheld for urban energy], [LIGHTING – single practical with halation], [PALETTE from chosen film card], [CAMERA – 35mm or 50mm at f/1.8 with shallow focus on the face], 35mm Kodak Vision 500T film grain, heavy halation, [ATMOSPHERE], in the style of [FILM TITLE], [mood register]. [negative prompt]

Worked example — ITMFL-register portrait

WORKED EXAMPLE

A woman in her late twenties in a deep crimson silk cheongsam with gold floral embroidery, high mandarin collar, cap sleeves, hair in a low 1960s chignon, seated on a wooden chair in a narrow 1962 Hong Kong Shanghainese boarding-house room, emerald-green floral-patterned wallpaper behind her, framed through an open doorway with a blurred dark doorframe filling the left 40% of the image (C1), lit by a single bare warm tungsten ceiling bulb producing halation and casting her face half in amber key and half in deep emerald shadow, amber-and-emerald split-toned palette with crimson accent dominant, shot on 35mm Kodak Vision 500T with an 85mm Zeiss prime at f/2, aspect ratio 1.66:1, fine organic film grain, cigarette smoke curling through the lamp light, humid still interior atmosphere, restrained melancholic register, gaze directed downward not at the camera, in the style of Wong Kar-wai's *In the Mood for Love* (2000), cinematography by Christopher Doyle and Mark Lee Ping-bing. --no modern clothing, sleeveless, loose hair, studio lighting, crushed blacks, HDR, oversaturated, direct eye contact, smiling, drone, fisheye, CGI, cartoon, text, watermark

13

Negative Prompt Block

Append this negative prompt to every Wong Kar-wai prompt without exception. These exclusions matter because AI defaults frequently produce the exact opposites of his aesthetic.

Universal negative prompt

UNIVERSAL NEGATIVE PROMPT

clean studio lighting, high-key illumination, flat neutral daylight, balanced three-point lighting, crushed pure-black shadows (#000000), blown-out highlights, HDR look, oversaturated Instagram filter, orange-and-teal Hollywood grade, clinical digital sharpness, flat untextured painted walls, modern minimalist interior, drone aerial shot, wide landscape establishing shot, fisheye distortion outside the Fallen Angels context, vertical 9:16 aspect ratio, shot-reverse-shot eye-contact dialogue framing, characters smiling broadly, characters making sustained direct eye contact, characters embracing or kissing unless the specific film permits it, modern clothing in period scenes, loose untied hair on 1960s female characters, Western clothing on 1960s cheongsam-era characters, clean CGI render, 3D cartoon style, anime, illustration, watercolour painterly treatment, commercial advertising gloss, modern fashion editorial polish, text, watermark, logo, signature, extra fingers, deformed hands

Midjourney shorthand

--NO PARAMETERS FOR MIDJOURNEY

--no modern, studio lighting, high-key, flat daylight, crushed blacks, HDR, oversaturated, Instagram, Hollywood grade, clinical sharpness, flat walls, drone, aerial, fisheye, vertical, shot-reverse-shot, smiling, eye contact, embrace, kiss, CGI, cartoon, anime, illustration, watercolour, commercial, watermark, text, extra fingers

The five most common failure modes

- 1. Clean high-key lighting.** Destroys the signature low-key practical-lit look. Wong Kar-wai is always underexposed and lit by a single visible practical source.
- 2. Pure-black shadows.** Breaks the coloured-shadow rule. Shadows carry emerald, teal, oxblood, or magenta information. Crushed blacks flatten the grade.
- 3. Direct eye contact between leads.** Collapses the emotional register of restraint. Characters almost never meet eyes in his frames.
- 4. Oversaturated Instagram grade.** Superficially similar but lacking the split-toned logic. The WKW grade is low global saturation with boosted red and green channels only.
- 5. Flat painted walls.** Every Wong Kar-wai wall is patterned, papered, textured, aged, damp, or covered in signage. Flat clean walls immediately break the aesthetic.

14

Quick-Reference Card

The Formula

MASTER FORMULA

[SUBJECT in period wardrobe] + [LOCATION with textured surface] + [LIGHTING: single warm practical from Section 08] + [COMPOSITION: through obstruction or strict profile from Section 09] + [PALETTE: from chosen film card in Section 11] + [CAMERA: 35mm Kodak 500T, lens, f-stop, aspect] + [ATMOSPHERE: smoke, rain, humidity, halation] + [MOOD: restraint / longing / melancholy from Section 06] + [ATTRIBUTE: DP + film title] + [NEGATIVE PROMPT from Section 13]

The Ten Non-Negotiables

1. Light is always motivated by a visible practical source in frame.
2. Shadows are never pure black — they carry saturated colour.
3. Every frame contains textured surfaces — no flat walls.
4. Characters rarely make direct eye contact within the same frame.
5. Faces are half-lit, partial, profiled, or reflected — rarely full frontal.
6. Mood takes priority over narrative clarity.
7. Film grain and halation are mandatory.
8. The camera is offset from the subject — rarely at direct eye level.
9. Slow motion is step-printed, not clean overcrank.
10. Colour is always graded — never realistic neutral.

The Universal Style Anchor

MEMORISE THIS ONE LINE

Wong Kar-wai cinematic style, 35mm Kodak Vision 500T film grain at [1.66:1 or 1.85:1 or 2.35:1], shot by [Christopher Doyle / Mark Lee Ping-bing / Philippe Le Sourd], single warm practical light source motivating every frame, split-toned colour grade with lifted coloured shadows, one saturated accent colour against desaturated surroundings, composed through doorways corridors curtains and reflections, handheld micro-drift, step-printed slow motion, patterned textured surfaces throughout, restrained melancholic mood of time slipping past unresolved desire, halation on every light source, cigarette smoke and rain filling the atmosphere, characters in strict profile rarely meeting eyes, the frame always telling a mood rather than a plot



End of reference. Hand this document to any capable AI image or video model as a system prompt, attach the relevant film palette card, and generate.